ENGLISH

An extract from Jazz Harper: Space Explorer

MARS YEAR 84

Nearly twenty Mars years ago, the extraordinary story of two children who discovered life on Mars heralded the beginning of a new era for the Marineris Colony and all humans living and working on the Red Planet.

Now, after many years, researchers have uncovered documents from the Marineris archives that shed new light on the discovery and the events leading to it.

Those documents are published here together for the first time. What follows is a story like no other...

28th May 2060

Dear Brand-New Diary of Adventure,

Today was our very last visit to Gran before our epic mission to Mars. Mum and I travelled there on the airtram, like usual. Did you know that airtrams travel really, really fast? I looked it up on the map app on my webspectacles as we sped over the tall tower blocks and green parks. At one point, we got up to two hundred and thirty-seven kilometres per hour!

I asked Mum if that's how fast we'll be travelling through space. She said the rocket will be much faster – over thirty thousand kilometres per hour!

Thirty thousand! That's mega fast. That's stomach-churning, brain-melting fast. Sometimes, when we're on the airtram, I play games to make the journey more fun. Today, I imagined I was a space pilot, speeding through the galaxy. Outside the windows, stars and planets zoomed past, blurring into streaks of light. An alien spaceship approached with lasers beaming but I was ready to zap it into another dimension as soon as it got into range.

"Pow! Pow-pow-pow! Pow!"

"Oh Jazz, you're not shooting aliens again," groaned Mum as the other people on the tram stared. "We LIKE aliens!"

I explained that they had us cornered in the outer spiral arm of a distant galaxy and that I had no choice.

Mum said I should, at least, try to bring one back alive so that she could study it. That's what Mum does for a living. She's an extraterrestrial-life researcher – an alien scientist.

I performed a lightning-speed U-turn to capture an alien fleeing the shattered spaceship in a life raft.

"Hmm," Mum said, pretending to investigate my captured alien. "It has bug eyes, seven legs, a spiky exoskeleton and liquid brains. This is like nothing I've ever seen before, Jazz. We could win the Galactic Discovery Prize for this."

"Do you think that's what alien life on Mars will look like?" I asked.

Mum laughed. "I doubt that they'll have seven legs. In fact, I doubt they'll have any legs at all."

I spent the rest of the journey thinking about Martians with tentacles and suckers, and some that crawled over the ground like slugs. When the airtram finally got to Sunset Heights, we released our seven-legged alien back into the wild and hopped onto the platform.

Gran lives in one of those old-fashioned retirement villages from the 2020s: all glass and steel and curving walls. When she isn't racing her friends around the courtyard on her hover scooter or throwing street parties on weeknights, she's in her top-floor flat, gazing through her binoculars at the happenings down below or inviting people over for a curry so hot that it makes your mouth burn.

I could smell Gran's curry as soon as we got upstairs. Even before the front door opened, my eyes watered.

Questions

1. What is the name of the colony on Mars that humans have established?

_____

2. From the first section, find and copy a phrase which suggests that the documents have not been seen before.

_____

_____

3. How fast will Jazz and her Mum be travelling through space? Tick one.

☐ two hundred and thirty-seven kilometres per hour

☐ one thousand kilometres per hour

☐ over thirty thousand kilometres per hour

☐ faster than light

4. What is Mum's job? Tick one.

☐ an extraterrestrial-life researcher ☐ a space pilot ☐ an airtram driver

5. Put a tick in the correct boxes to show which descriptions Mum uses to describe the pretend alien.

Mum's Description

☐ bug eyes

☐ a spiky exoskeleton

☐ three legs

☐ no brains

6. Put a tick in each row to show whether the events really happened in the story or were imagined by Jazz.

	Really Happened in the Story	Imagined by Jazz
Mum and Jazz travelled by airtram.		
Jazz looked up the map using webspectacles.		
Stars and planets zoomed past the windows.		
Jazz was shooting aliens.		

7. How did Mum feel about Jazz's imaginary game?

_____

_____

Questions

1. In what year is the first section of the story set?

2. Find and copy a phrase or sentence in the first section that builds anticipation of the story that comes next and entices the reader to find out more.

3. What transport does Jazz use to visit Gran? Tick one.

   ☐ spaceship ☐ car ☐ airtram ☐ hover scooter

4. How do you know that this is the typical way in which Jazz travels to visit her Gran?

5. Find and copy a phrase that reveals that Jazz is not actually capturing aliens in this extract.

6. In what kind of accommodation does Gran live?

7. Look at the line: 'I could smell Gran's curry as soon as we got upstairs. Even before the front door opened, my eyes watered.' What does this suggest about Gran's curry?

8. Mum and Jazz appear to have a fun relationship and get along well. What evidence is there to support this?